suggestion. After a long pause, Dr Arunachalam replied, “We beg for time to rethink and return, Sir!” “You come back tomorrow morning please,” the Defence Minister replied. It was reminiscent of Prof. Sarabhai’s zeal and vision. That night, Dr Arunachalam and I laboured together on reworking our plan.

We worked out some very important extensions and improvements in our proposal, taking al the variables, such as design, fabrication, system integration, qualification, experimental flights, evaluation, updating, user trials, producibility, quality, reliability, and financial viability into account. We then integrated them into a single function of total accountability, in order to meet the needs of the country’s armed forces with an indigenous endeavour. We worked out the concepts of design, development, production concurrency and proposed the participation of user and inspection agencies right from the drawing-board stage. We also suggested a methodology to achieve state-of-the-art systems after al the years of developmental activities. We wanted to deliver contemporary missiles to our Services and not some outdated inventory of weapons. It was a very exciting chal enge that had been thrown to us.